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THE SAFFRON ONSLAUGHT

With PM Modi's shining armour as their beacon, the BJP seems poised to sweep the state again. Inflation matters, voices asking for jobs are lost in the Opposition vacuum

By Jumana Shah



ANI

Gujarati *asmita* (pride) is by now a given in Gujarat, and continues to dominate the political narrative as popular son of the state Narendra Modi seeks the mandate for a third term as India's prime minister. The state votes on May 7, but pride in their identity will not be the only guiding concern of the 49.2 million voters this time. Across the towns and villages, the chorus is all about unemployment, question paper leaks in recruitment exams and inflation. Of course, this by no means diminishes Modi's popularity, nor will it throw up a surprise in the vote.

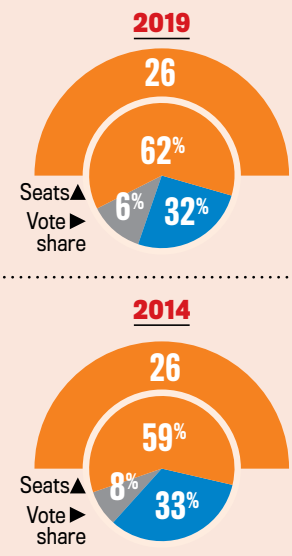
Ahmedabad-based social activist Mittal Patel, who works extensively in the state's rural areas, says, "I hear women complain that vegetables and pulses have become unaffordable. Yes, there is a thrill about voting for *aapdo manas* (PM Modi), but the people are restless," she says. Aware of this growing disaffection, the BJP is ensuring the party cadre do not slip into complacency in the face of a comatose Congress-Aam Aadmi Party alliance. And so it has shifted the goal posts—the target being to win every seat by a margin of 500,000 votes. That campaign started early with candidates for all 26 seats announced by mid-March, but the narrative went sideways after Rajkot candidate and Union minister Parshottam Rupala's comments at a Dalit event about the state's erstwhile Rajput rulers marrying off their daughters to the British colonisers even as they oppressed the masses. The furore it caused had the Kshatriya cohort baying for blood. Despite the apologies and meetings with community leaders, they have not backed down. Earlier, they wanted Rupala replaced, failing which they have turned to mobilising votes against the BJP. Party leaders are confident the community will come around before polling day, but even if they don't, the Kshatriyas make up just 4-5 per cent of the electorate and are scattered across the state. The party has also had to replace two candidates—Ranjan Bhatt in Vadodara and Bhikhaji Thakor in Sabarkantha—after "internal protests", in what was an unusual outburst by the cadre.

The Congress, meanwhile, was struggling to find credible faces after three leaders—Bharatsinh Solanki, Jagdish Thakor and Rohan Gupta—refused to contest. Gupta, a second-generation leader, was the Congress candidate from Ahmedabad (East) but backtracked and joined the BJP. Some days earlier, state president and ex-Opposition leader Arjun Modhwadia and MLA C.J. Chavda had also jumped ship. The two are now the BJP candidates for the Porbandar and Vijapur assembly seats

PERFECT SCORES

LOK SABHA

Total LS seats: 26



Vote share figures have been rounded off